brilliance of the younger man's batting; they could have formed a devastating partnership for England.

Realistically, though, international teams are in a constant state of transition. Ian Bell called, just after 9 p.m. on the night before we collected the Ashes at the Oval in 2015 and asked for a chat over a beer in the bar. I was surprised by the timing of the request, but Belly had, in his understated way, struggled in that series. I had seen signs of internal turmoil and was planning to speak to him after the celebrations in any case. The biggest giveaway involved him making a conscious change to his daily routine, by getting to the ground ridiculously early. That hinted at a deeper sense of unease, because he was a quiet guy who internalized things. If Belly needed help in any way, I would be there for him. He had been one of the pillars of my captaincy, a selfless individual, who had put his heart and soul into the game. He simply delivered.

We spoke for an hour that evening, starting with small talk about his beloved Aston Villa before getting down to the nitty gritty. He told me he was thinking about retirement and valued my insight. I argued against making a snap decision. It wouldn't be irreversible, but it would set in chain a series of events. 'I don't see a bloke who is ready to retire,' I told him. 'I see a bloke who is tired. I see a bloke who needs a break from international cricket. I don't see a bloke who is gone.'

His talent had been spotted early, and mined relentlessly, for nigh on sixteen years. Like many of us, he had dealt with his own insecurities while balancing a heavy workload and a growing family. That journey, through England's Under-19s, A team and senior side, is a marathon, and it is not uncommon to hit the wall along the way. You get to know people pretty well as a captain, or at least you think you do. Belly spoke about having had his fill, but I sensed that, deep down, he suspected he wasn't done with the game. As we sat together, chatting quietly, it became clear he didn't want to be seen to be taking the easy option. He wasn't keen on a sabbatical, because it is a big thing to give away your place without the finality of retirement. He agreed he should carry on.

That three-Test trip, against Pakistan in the United Arab Emirates in October and November, didn't break him, but it justified his unease. It was fiendishly hot, a grind, and I felt compelled to administer a rare bollocking to the entire group, when I sensed standards slipping. This wasn't